

Reading the source: *Gilgamesh*, Tablet XI

FRST 110 · Water Makes Worlds · Friday, September 25 · Flood narratives, 1 of 3

Tablet XI · “Gilgamesh said to him”

Sophus Helle, trans., *Gilgamesh: A New Translation of the Ancient Epic* (Yale, 2021), Tablet XI, pp. 100–112: the pages in your flood narratives pamphlet. The numbers in the margin are Helle’s line numbers, so you can cite a line as XI 185.

p. 100

Gilgamesh said to him, to the faraway Uta-napishti:

“I look at you, Uta-napishti,

and your body is no different, you are just like me.

You are no different, you are just like me!

“My heart was all set on fighting with you,

but now that I see you, my arm falls limp.

Tell me, how did you find eternal life in the gathering of gods?”

Uta-napishti said to him, to Gilgamesh:

“I will tell you a secret, Gilgamesh,

and reveal what the gods keep hidden.

“You know the city of Shuruppak,

the city that lies on the banks of the Euphrates.

That city was old, and the great gods were there

when their hearts led them to unleash the Flood.

“They swore an oath of silence: Father Anu,

the hero Enlil, adviser of gods,

their throne-bearer, young Ninurta,

and Ennugi, watchman of the waterways.

PERSON

Uta-napishti

The one man who survived the Flood. The gods made him and his wife immortal and sent them to live at the edge of the world. Gilgamesh, afraid of dying since his friend Enkidu died, has travelled there to ask him how.

5

10

PLACE

Shuruppak

One of the oldest cities of Sumer, on the Euphrates in what is now southern Iraq.

15

PERSON

The gods who swore

Anu, god of the sky and father of the gods. Enlil, their leader, lord of the earth. Ninurta, a warrior god, Enlil’s son. Ennugi, the god in charge of the canals.

“Lord Ea was also sworn to silence,
but he repeated their words to a wall:
‘Fence, fence! Wall, wall!
Hear me, fence! Heed me, wall!’

20

PERSON

Ea

God of fresh water and of cleverness. He lives in the Apsû, and he is the one god who looks out for humans.

TERM

Why a wall?

Ea has sworn not to tell. So he tells the wall of Uta-napishti’s house, and Uta-napishti, on the other side, hears. When Enlil later accuses him, Ea says he “did not reveal the secret” to anyone.

p. 101

“‘Man of Shuruppak, son of Ubara-tutu!
Raze the house, build a boat,
leave wealth, look for life,
forget your goods, save yourself!
And bring on board the seed of all life.

25

“‘The ship you will build:
let her measures match up,
make her as wide as she is long,
and roof her over, like the Apsû.’

30

PLACE

The Apsû

The ocean of fresh water under the earth, where springs and rivers come from. It is Ea’s home.

“‘I understood and said to Ea:
‘Master, I have received your order,
I heard what you said, I will do it.
But how should I answer the city, the crowds, and the elders?’

35

“‘Ea worked his words, saying to me, his servant:
‘You will say to them this:

“‘“Surely, Enlil must hate me!
I can no longer live in your city
and set my feet on Enlil’s land.
I will go down to the Apsû,
to live with my lord Ea.

40

“‘“On you he will rain
a shower of birds, a windfall of fish,
you will reap a deluge of riches!

45

““““At dawn sweets,
at dusk wheat
in downpours he
will rain on you.””

““““At dawn dark,
at dusk death
for all he will
let fall on you.””””

TERM

Two columns, one line

The same Akkadian words can be read two ways. The word for a kind of cake sounds like the word for darkness, and the word for wheat sounds like the word for disaster. Helle prints both readings side by side: the city hears a promise of food, and the same words announce the Flood.

PERSON

Atra-hasis

Another name for Uta-napishti. It means “exceedingly wise.”

“At the first flood of daylight,
the city gathered at the gate of Atra-hasis.

p. 102

“The carpenter brought his ax,
the thatcher brought his stone,
the shipwright brought his adze.

“The young men came with
the old men brought ropes,
the rich came with pitch,
the poor brought whatever they had.

“By the fifth day, I had laid out the hull of the ship:
her area was an acre, her sides two hundred feet tall,
and her deck was the same, two hundred feet wide.

“Then I drew the design and laid out her frame:
Six times I decked her over,
dividing her into seven decks,
each deck I divided into nine cabins.

I drove water plugs into her belly,
found poles and mounted the tackle.

“I poured ten thousand gallons of tar into the furnace
and coated the boat with ten thousand gallons of pitch.
The water boys brought ten thousand gallons of oil:
one-third of it was poured out in sacrifice,
and the boatman stowed the rest away.

TERM

Adze

A woodworking tool like an ax, with the blade set crosswise, for shaping beams.

TERM

The dots

Words are missing here: the clay tablet is broken. The dots mark the gap. They appear a few more times in the tablet.

50

55

60

65

70

"I butchered oxen for the workmen,
and every day I slaughtered sheep.
I let all my ale, beer, oil, and wine
flow like rivers for the workmen,
they drank like it was New Year's!

75

"At dawn I began to oil the wood,
by sundown the ship was finished.
". . . difficult.

p. 103

We kept carrying rollers for the slipway back and forth,
until two-thirds of the ship was in the water.

80

"I brought everything I had on board:
I brought on board all the silver I had,
I brought on board all the gold I had,
I brought on board the seed of all life.

"I sent on board all my family and kin,
the herds and the creatures of the wild,
and the experts of all kinds of crafts.

85

"The sun had set me a deadline:

"At dawn sweets,	"At dawn dark,
at dusk wheat	at dusk death
in downpours he	for all he will
will rain on you.	let fall on you.

"Go on board and seal the hatch:
the time has arrived.

90

"At dawn sweets,	"At dawn dark,
at dusk wheat	at dusk death
in downpours he	for all he will
will rain on you.'	let fall on you.'

"I watched the weather,
the storm was terrifying.
So I went on board and sealed the hatch.
I gave my palace and all its treasure to Puzur-Enlil,
the shipwright who caulked the hatch from outside.

95

"At the first flood of daylight,
a black cloud rose on the horizon.

p. 104

“Adad the Storm God was roaring inside it,
Thunder and Lightning marched at the front,
bearing his throne over mountains and plains.

100

“Erra, god of war, ripped out the moorings,
the dikes overflowed as Ninurta walked by.

The Anunnaki gods came bearing torches,
burning the land with their frightful light.

105

“The Storm God’s silence covered the skies,
and all that was bright turned dark.
Like an ox, he trampled on the land,
and it shattered like a pot of clay.

“For a full day, the wind blew,
it stormed from the east and brought the Flood
that spread like war over the country.

110

“Brothers looked in vain for each other:
men all looked the same in the slaughter.

“Even the gods grew afraid of the Flood;
they fled to the skies, they flew up to Anu;
the gods curled up like dogs in the cold.
The goddess wailed like a woman giving birth,
the sweet-voiced Belet-ili screamed:

115

“‘All the past has turned to clay,
because I spoke evil in the gathering of gods.
How could I speak evil in the gathering of gods?

120

“‘I declared a war to destroy the human people,
but I am their mother—the people were mine!
Now like fish they fill the sea.’

p. 105

“The Anunnaki gods wept with her.
The gods slumped and sat in tears,
while fever parched their lips.

125

“For six days and seven nights, the wind blew.
The storm and the Flood flattened the land.

TERM

The Anunnaki

A name for the great gods as a group.

PERSON

Belet-ili

“Lady of the gods,” the mother goddess who made human beings. That is why she says, “I am their mother.”

“When the seventh day arrived, 130
 the storm relented . . .
 The sea, which had fought like a woman in labor,
 found peace, the wind stilled, the Flood ended.

 “I watched the weather; it was quiet,
 but all the people had turned to clay. 135

 “The flooded land was flat as a rooftop.
 I opened a hatch and felt the sun on my face.
 I fell to my knees and wept,
 the tears streaming down my cheeks.

 “I looked for land, for an end to the sea, 140
 and found fourteen peaks rising from the water.
 The ship ran aground on the Mountain of Secrets,
 the mountain held on to it and would not let go.

 “One day and a second, the mountain held on and would not let
 go.
 A third day and a fourth, the mountain held on and would not let 145
 go.
 A fifth day and a sixth, the mountain held on and would not let go.

 “When the seventh day arrived,
 I brought out a dove and set it free.
 The dove flew off, but then it returned.
 It found nowhere to land, so it came back. 150

 “I brought out a swallow and set it free.
 The swallow flew off, but then it returned.
 It found nowhere to land, so it came back.

p. 106
 “I brought out a crow and set it free.
 The crow flew off and saw the sea ebb away, 155
 it pecked, hopped around, and did not come back.

 “I brought out a sacrifice to the four winds
 and offered incense to the mountain peak.
 I laid out seven offering bowls, and seven more,
 with sweet reed, cedar, and myrtle underneath. 160

PLACE

The Mountain of Secrets

Helle translates the mountain's Akkadian name. It is usually placed in the Zagros mountains, in what is now northern Iraq.

“The gods smelled the scent,
the gods smelled the sweet scent,
the gods swarmed to the sacrifice like flies.

“As soon as Belet-ili arrived,
she held up the mighty jeweled flies
that Anu had made to seduce her:
‘Gods! I will hang these flies like beads round my neck,
to remind me of these days—I must never forget!

““Now let the gods all come to the sacrifice.
Only Enlil is not welcome at the sacrifice,
because he caused the Flood, acting without counsel,
consigning my people to the slaughter.’

“As soon as Enlil arrived,
he saw the ship and was furious.
He grew angry with the Igigi gods:
‘How did this living creature escape?
No one was to survive the slaughter!’

“Ninurta worked his words, saying to Enlil the hero:
‘Who could have done this, if not Ea?
There is nothing Ea cannot do.’

“Ea worked his words, saying to Enlil the hero:
‘You, the hero, the sage of the gods!
How could you cause the Flood, acting without counsel?

p. 107

““Only culprits should bear the crime,
only the guilty should bear the guilt!
Slacken the rope so it does not snap,
or pull it taut so it does not slacken!

““Instead of the Flood you unleashed,
lions could have come to cull humankind.
Instead of the Flood you unleashed,
wolves could have come to cull humankind.
Instead of the Flood you unleashed,
famine could have come to cull humankind.
Instead of the Flood you unleashed,
war could have come to cull humankind.

TERM

The jeweled flies

A necklace of beads carved in the shape of flies, from the blue stone lapis lazuli, a love gift from Anu. She swears by it never to forget.

TERM

The Igigi

The younger gods, lower in rank than the great gods.

TERM

The rope

A saying about measure: do not pull so hard that everything breaks, and do not let go altogether. Ea is telling Enlil the punishment was too much.

“I did not reveal the secret of the great gods to Atra-hasis,
I only let him see a dream, where he heard the gods’ secret.
Now, decide what to do with him.’

“Enlil came aboard my boat,
he took my hands and led me out,
he led out my wife and made her kneel by my side.
He stood between us and touched our brows, blessing us:

“In the past, Uta-napishti was human,
now he and his wife will be like us gods!
Uta-napishti shall live far away, where the rivers rise.’
They took me far away and made me live where rivers rise.

“But now, what will convene the gods for your sake,
Gilgamesh, so you too can find the life that you seek?
Come, try to stay awake for six days and seven nights!”

But as soon as Gilgamesh squatted down,
sleep blew over him like a fog.

p. 108

Uta-napishti said to her, to his wife:

“Look at that young man, who wants eternal life!
Sleep blows over him like a fog.”

His wife said to him, to the faraway Uta-napishti:

“Touch him, let the man wake up!
By the road that he came, let him go home unharmed,
let him go back through the gate that he crossed.”

Uta-napishti said to her, to his wife:

“Humans are deceitful, he too will deceive you.
Come, bake his daily bread and set it by his head,
and make a mark on the wall for each day he sleeps.”

She baked his daily bread and set it by his head,
and made a mark on the wall for each day he slept.

200

205

210

215

220

PLACE

Where the rivers rise

The far edge of the world, where the rivers begin. To reach it Gilgamesh had to cross the Waters of Death.

TERM

Convene the gods

Uta-napishti became immortal because the gods met and decided it, after the Flood.

His first bread was all dried out,
the second was tough as leather,
the third had some moisture left,
the fourth had turned white,
the fifth was showing spots,
the sixth was still fresh
and the seventh was on the coals
when he touched and woke up the man.

225

Gilgamesh said to him, to the faraway Uta-napishti:
“Sleep seems to have seized me a moment,
but straight away you touched and woke me!”

Uta-napishti said to him, to Gilgamesh:
“Come, Gilgamesh, count out your daily bread,
and realize how long you slept.

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235

“Your first bread is all dried out,
the second is tough as leather,

p. 109

the third has some moisture left,
the fourth has turned white,
the fifth is showing spots,
the sixth is still fresh
and the seventh was on the coals
when you woke up.”

240

Gilgamesh said to him, to Uta-napishti:
“How can I go on, Uta-napishti? Where should I go?
The Thief of Life has a hold on my heart.
Death is sitting in my bedroom,
and wherever I turn, there too is death.”

245

Uta-napishti said to him, to the boatman Ur-shanabi:
“Ur-shanabi! May the dock disown you, the ferry detest you!
You, who used to walk this shore, shall long for it.

PERSON

Ur-shanabi

Uta-napishti's ferryman. He brought Gilgamesh across the Waters of Death.

TERM

A curse

Uta-napishti banishes Ur-shanabi for bringing a living man across. He can never come back, so he leaves with Gilgamesh.

“The man you led here,
whose body is covered with filthy hair,
whose beauty is spoiled by dirty pelts:

“Take him, Ur-shanabi, bring him to the bathtub.
Wash his hair with water, as clean as it can be,
take off those pelts and throw them in the sea.

“Bathe his beautiful body!
Find a new scarf for his head,
give him a royal mantle worthy of his dignity.

“Until he arrives home in his city,
until he reaches the end of his road,
the mantle will stay new and unblemished.”

Ur-shanabi took him and brought him to the bathtub.
He washed his hair with water, as clean as it could be,
he took off the pelts and threw them in the sea.

p. 110

He bathed his beautiful body,
found a new scarf for his head,
and gave him a royal mantle worthy of his dignity.

Until he arrived home in his city,
until he reached the end of his road,
the mantle would stay new and unblemished.

Gilgamesh and Ur-shanabi boarded the boat,
they launched the ferry and sailed away.

His wife said to him, to the faraway Uta-napishti:
“Gilgamesh struggled and strained to come here,
and what did you give him to bring back home?”

Then Gilgamesh raised the punting pole
and brought the boat back to shore.

Uta-napishti said to him, to Gilgamesh:
“Gilgamesh, you struggled and strained to come here,
and what did I give you to bring back home?

“I will tell you a secret, Gilgamesh,
and reveal what the gods keep hidden.

“There is a plant that looks like a thistle,
whose thorns, like a wild rose, hurt your hands.
If you can find and pluck this plant,
you will win back your life force.”

285

When Gilgamesh heard this,
he dug a shaft down to the Apsû ·
He tied heavy stones to his feet,
they pulled him down to the Apsû · ·

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p. 111

He grasped and plucked the plant, it hurt his hand,
then he cut the heavy stones from his feet
and the sea threw him back on the beach.

Gilgamesh said to him, to the boatman Ur-shanabi:
“Ur-shanabi, this is the plant of the pulsing heart,
the man who finds it will win back his life force.

295

“I will bring it home to Uruk the Sheepfold
and try it out, I will make an old man eat from it.
If the old man grows young again,
I will eat it too, and return to my youth.”

300

PLACE

Uruk the Sheepfold

Gilgamesh's city, on the Euphrates in what is now southern Iraq. “The Sheepfold” is an old title for the city: its king was called the shepherd of his people.

They stopped to eat after a hundred miles,
they pitched camp after two hundred miles more.
Gilgamesh found a pool with cool water,
he went down to swim in the pool.

A snake smelled the scent of the plant,
it slid up in silence, it snatched it away
and shed its skin as it slithered back.

305

Then Gilgamesh sat down crying,
tears streaming down his cheeks.
· · and said to the boatman Ur-shanabi:

310

“Ur-shanabi, I have worn out my arms—and for whom?
For whom did I spill the blood of my heart?
I got my reward, but not for myself,
I gave it instead to this underground lion!

TERM

The underground lion

The snake. “Lion of the earth” was an Akkadian name for a snake.

“Now all around us the tide has been rising.
When I dug the shaft, I threw away the tools.
And if I went back, how could I find the same spot?
I even left the boat on the beach.”

p. 112

They stopped to eat after a hundred miles,
they pitched camp after two hundred miles more.
They arrived at Uruk the Sheepfold,
and Gilgamesh said to him, to Ur-shanabi:

“Climb the wall of Uruk, Ur-shanabi! Walk its length.
Survey the foundation, study the brickwork.
There—is it not made of oven-baked bricks?
Did the Seven Sages not lay its cornerstone?

“Look: Two thousand acres for the city,
two thousand acres for the orchards,
two thousand acres for the pits of clay,
and one thousand acres for the temple of Ishtar.
Seven thousand acres is the size of Uruk.”

315

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IMAGE OR ECHO

Where the epic began

These lines repeat the opening of the whole epic, in Tablet I, almost word for word.

PERSON

The Seven Sages

Seven wise beings who, in the time before the Flood, taught people how to build cities, write and farm.

PERSON

Ishtar

Goddess of love and war, and the goddess of Uruk.